

or welding and operate in many locations. All travel expenses are covered by the program in addition to a small stipend. Assignments vary from one week to several months long.

8. Financial Services Volunteer Corps

FSVC (www.fsvc.org) places business, legal, and finance professionals in developing and reforming economies to provide education and guidance. They cover all expenses and operate primarily in Central and Eastern Europe, Africa, and Asia. Assignments typically last one week.

ALMOST-FREE PROGRAMS

Willing Workers on Organic Farms (www.WWOInternational.org) places volunteers on organic farms around the world. While working, your room and board at the farm is free, though volunteers are responsible for all expenses involved in getting to and from the site. Volunteers must pay a small annual membership fee to join the organization in the country they wish to work in order to access the database of farms. This is a great opportunity to learn about organic farming and spend a few days to a few months doing some fun physical work.

Finally, there are a number of “work camps” worldwide that place teams of volunteers on a two- or three-week project. These can involve everything from farming to construction, education to art; every project is different. It costs about \$170 plus up to \$400 in fees for two or three weeks of room, board, and work. Not free, but not bad for two weeks of traveling. These projects are organized through clearinghouses, the most popular being Volunteers for Peace (www.vfp.org) and Service Civil International (www.sci.ngo). Volunteers For Peace charges \$500 per project and offers custom arrangements for families.

Keep in mind that these trips will not be a week sitting on the beach. You will have to work, but even if you are doing something related to your everyday job, the location and unique challenges will make it seem fresh and new.

Besides a vacation, these opportunities provide an opportunity to learn a new language, take a leadership role, experience everyday life in a foreign country, and make some new friends and professional connections. With experiences like that, maybe it is smart to take a vacation during a recession. — **David DeFranza**